time. The *Lawoe*, reported a beaming *Bande Mataram*, was ‘in excellent condition, accommodation being perfect and engine machinery new’, while the *Gallia* had had a pleasant voyage out.[76] The *Lawoe*, which had arrived with general cargo, was moored in the Victoria Docks, Bombay.[77]

The sight of the steamers sent the Swadeshis into a tizzy. The *Gallia* was ‘furnished with beautiful saloons, smoking rooms, and up-to-date accommodation fitted with artistic electric lights, electric fans, etc’, gushed the *Mahratta*, adding with unconcealed pride, ‘She is worth seeing.’ It could run at ‘an extraordinary speed’ of 18 to 20 knots an hour.[78] A speciality of the *Gallia* was its water service. The water drawn from an independent pump in the engine room, once used, was drained by another pipe attached to the wash basin.[79] The company was so proud of the acquisition that it welcomed the public to view her, an invitation taken up by many.[80]

To celebrate the purchase, a reception was organized aboard the *Gallia* by SSNCo’s Bombay Agents, Soonderdas Dhurumsey & Co. ‘A number of ladies and gentlemen mustered strong’ to view the ship. The first-class saloon was overflowing with visitors as Captain Chapman, the master of the ship, raised a toast to the success of the company. Alim Mohammed Bimji, described as ‘a well-known figure on Congress platform’ and others offered felicitation to ‘one of the best steamers ever seen’. VOC, the star of the occasion, accepted the felicitation ‘in suitable terms’. In the general mood of bonhomie several shares were subscribed to on the spot. With all flags hoisted up and all electric lights well lit up, the *Gallia* presented a splendid sight.[81]

Arriving at Tuticorin

VOC was no doubt in a hurry to bring the *Gallia* to Tuticorin. But it was a week before it could leave Bombay because a fresh passenger certificate was now required.[82] So it was on 13 April that the *Gallia* could set sail to Tuticorin.[83]